BHOLARAM KA JEEV

(A Modern Adaptation)
Written by
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ACT ONE

SCENE 1.
INT. IRRIGATION DEPARTMENT - FLASHBACK - DAY (35 YEARS AGO)

A young, straight-backed BHOLARAM (30), crisp white shirt tucked in, moustache neatly groomed, stamps files on his small desk with speed and pride. Behind him, a poster on the wall reads: "Karam hi Dharam hai." (in hindi)

An older SUPERVISOR watches him work, nodding, pleased.

SUPERVISOR
Bholaram, tumhare jaise imaandar clerk kam milte hain. Pura department tumhari kaam ki tareef karta hai.

BHOLARAM
(young, prim and proper)
Sarkar ka kaam hai sahab. Poori imaandari se karunga, aakhri din tak.

SUPERVISOR
Aur retire hone ke baad? Sarkar tumhara khayal rakhegi. Yeh vaada hai humara.

Young Bholaram smiles and stamps another file. The stamp comes down: THWACK. The sound blends seamlessly into—

SCENE 2.
INT. PENSION OFFICE - DAY

The same THWACK, decades later, now carrying no pride, only weariness. The air is heavy with dust, sorrow, and the slow, rhythmic thwack of a rubber stamp. The color palette is sepia-toned, a dull, oppressive yellow. Overhead, ceiling fans wobble, merely stirring the hot air around.

Mountains of files bound in faded red string stand everywhere. A crooked, hand-painted wooden sign hangs from the ceiling: "PENSIONS."

BHOLARAM (65) stands at the counter, utterly unlike the eager young man of thirty years ago. He is frail, exhausted, deep wrinkles etched on his face. An old striped shirt hangs loosely on his thin frame. In trembling hands he clutches a thick manila folder stamped in red ink: "PENSION PENDING."

Behind the counter sits JUNIOR CLERK (30s), his whole demeanor as though built to ignore the public. He is completely absorbed in his phone, a half-empty cutting chai resting on a pile of important documents.

BHOLARAM
(hesitantly)
Sahab... pichle mahine bola thha aapne. Application jama kar di thhi.

Junior Clerk doesn't even look up. Keeps swiping his screen.

JUNIOR CLERK
Bahar board nahi padha kya? Lunch time hone wala hai.

BHOLARAM
Par sahab, subah se khada hoon. Bas ek signature baaki thha... Tiwari ji ka. Retire hue paanch saal ho gaye. Pension ka ek paisa nahi aaya.

Junior Clerk finally lets out a long breath, looks up with deep irritation. He lazily points toward Bholaram's folder.

JUNIOR CLERK
Dikhao file.

Bholaram quickly opens the folder, showing with trembling hands a whole stack of forms, photocopies, and affidavits. The Clerk looks at it for less than two seconds.

JUNIOR CLERK
(handing him a random sheet of paper)

Yeh form 16-B kahan hai? Aur verification stamp? Yeh officer ka sign kisne kiya hai? Yeh nahi chalega.

BHOLARAM
Aap hi ne toh bola thha pichli baar! Maine sab lagaya hai sir, dekhiye--

JUNIOR CLERK
Arre main kya antaryami hoon? Niyam badalte rehte hain. Naya form bhar ke laao. Aur Tiwari ji chhutti pe hain. Agle mahine aana. Next!

Bholaram stands frozen, as though something has stunned him. He slowly closes the folder. He turns and looks at the long lines of old, tired people — everyone here is, in some way, a reflection of himself. A lifetime of service has, in old age, become nothing but waiting.

SCENE 3.
INT. BHOLARAM'S HOUSE - NIGHT

A cramped, windowless, lower-middle-class room. Plaster is peeling from the damp walls. A single harsh tube light casts a sickly glow over the room.

Bholaram sits on a broken plastic chair, staring blankly at the wall. The "PENSION PENDING" folder rests in his lap.

His WIFE (60s), equally exhausted, in an old sari, brings him two dry rotis and a steel plate of thin dal. Their DAUGHTER (28) sits in the corner, quietly slipping a stiff, formal letter back into its envelope.

WIFE
Khana kha lijiye. Subah se bhookhe hain.

Bholaram doesn't move.

BHOLARAM
(Whispering to himself)
Tiwari ji chhutti pe hain.

WIFE

Kucch bola unhone aaj? Paisa aayega?
Bijli wale warning deke gaye hain aaj.
Kirana wala udhaar nahi de raha.

Their daughter speaks softly, not looking at her father, the envelope still in her hand.

DAUGHTER
Papa... Sharma ji ke ladke wali baat, unhone mana kar diya. Bola dahej mein... jab tak pension clear nahi hoti, woh log ruk nahi sakte.

A long, unbearable silence. Bholaram's jaw tightens.

BHOLARAM
Naya form... 16-B...

He looks at his wife. Her eyes are hollow.

BHOLARAM
(cont'd)
Main thak gaya hoon, Kamla. Bahut thak gaya hoon. Paintees saal is sarkar ko diye. Aaj usi sarkar ke saamne bhikari ki tarah khada hoon.

Suddenly he clutches his chest. The folder slips from his lap, papers scattering across the cracked linoleum floor. He gasps for air.

WIFE
(Screaming)
Suniye! Kya hua? Padosi ko bulao! Koi hai!

Bholaram collapses onto the floor. The camera pushes in on his face, surrounded by the shroud-like papers scattered around him, until his eyes go still.

SCENE 4.
INT. BHOLARAM'S HOUSE - DAY

The same room, now filled with mourning relatives. The light is dim. In the middle of the room, Bholaram's lifeless body, wrapped in a clean white shroud, lies adorned with marigold flowers.

Behind, family members are weeping.

The camera moves down to Bholaram's feet. A strange, official-looking cardboard tag is tied to his toe. Written on it in clear black letters:

"BODY: FOUND / SOUL: MISSING." (can also be illustration)

ACT TWO

SCENE 5.
INT. DEPARTMENT OF AFTERLIFE - DAY

The scene abruptly shifts — to an ultra-modern, lifeless corporate boardroom. An atmosphere of rigid, cold efficiency. Sleek concrete walls, glass partitions, and slate-grey tones. Like the headquarters of some billion-dollar tech company.

Behind a vast mahogany desk, brushed steel lettering on the wall reads: "YAMRAJ — CHAIRMAN - विभाग – परलोक प्रशासन"

YAMRAJ sits behind the desk. He is not the mythological, conch-and-mace-wielding deity. He resembles a sharp, powerful corporate emperor — black suit, crisp white shirt, dark silk tie, black aviator sunglasses, the iconic moustache. He radiates total authority.

To his right sits CHITRAGUPT, Chief Accounts Officer. Sharp grey suit, wire-frame glasses, permanently anxious expression. His fingers move rapidly across a glowing tablet.

Behind them, a vast screen runs a dashboard headed: "आत्मा पुनर्प्राप्ति विशेष कार्यबल" Below it a list reads: पता लगाएँ / सत्यापित करें / परलोक में लाएँ

YAMRAJ
(In a serious, authoritative tone)
Trimaasik lakshya kam ho rahe hain, Chitragupt. Punarjanm-tantra mein bhaar badh gaya hai. Mujhe vichitr maamlon ki suchi do.

CHITRAGUPT
(Tapping away on the tablet)

Ji Maharaj. Ek gambhir truti mili hai tantra mein. Prakaran sankhya 884-B. Naam: Bholaram.

YAMRAJ
Sthiti kya hai?

CHITRAGUPT
Yahi toh vishay hai, Maharaj. Sthool sharir ko Prithvi par surakshit kar liya gaya hai. Mrityu-pariksha ho chuki hai. Antim sanskar ki taiyari chal rahi hai. Parantu aatma...

Chitragupt pauses, adjusting his glasses.

CHITRAGUPT
(Cont'd)
Aatma ne abhi tak panjikaran nahi karvaya hai, Maharaj.

Yamraj slowly lowers his aviators, staring straight over the top of them.

YAMRAJ
Yeh kya kaha tumne? Bhala kisi bhi aatma ka poorn roop se digital, cloud-aadharit parlok mein lapata hona kaise sambhav hai? Humne sarvar toh pichle sahasrabdi mein hi unnat kar diye the, isi ke liye toh.

CHITRAGUPT
Maharaj, maine teen baar jaanch ki hai. Woh Antarlok mein nahi hai. Marg mein bhi nahi hai. Digital chinh bas ruk jaata hai, ant ho jaata hai. Abhilekh wahi hain, ab digital roop mein, parantu adhoore.

YAMRAJ
(Lambi saans lete hue)
Ashcharyajanak. Mrityu ke paschaat bhi, yeh tantra vifal ho jaata hai. Ek Yamdoot bhejo. Bholaram ki aatma dhoondo aur use turant yahan laao. Agli sabha se pehle yeh vishay sulajhaya jaana chahiye.

CHITRAGUPT
Maharaj -- ek aur baat. Is trimaas ka yeh chautha lapata-aatma prakaran hai. Chaaron, sarkari pension-abhilekh. Mujhe yeh sanyog nahi lagta.

Yamraj pauses a moment to take this in. Then waves a dismissive hand.

YAMRAJ
Sanyog ho ya prataah, mujhe aaj sandhya tak ek prakaran band chahiye. Yamdoot ko bhejo.

SCENE 6.
EXT. DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC SERVICES - DAY

A massive, forbidding brutalist concrete government building. The architecture is designed to make every person feel small. A faded, dusty sign reads: "DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC SERVICES."

Hundreds of weary citizens stand in long, endless lines in the heat, just as Bholaram once stood.

A YAMDOOT (Messenger of Death) arrives. He doesn't look demonic. He looks like a high-ranking field agent or a tax auditor — black suit, dark tie, aviators, a gleaming leather folder in hand.

He regards the building with deep disdain. He straightens his sleeve and steps into the ocean of bureaucracy.

SCENE 7.
INT. DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC SERVICES - LOBBY - DAY

Yamdoot heads straight for the gate, but a SECURITY GUARD manning a rusted metal detector stops him.

SECURITY GUARD
Token lijiye pehle. Visitor entry ke liye token zaroori hai.

YAMDOOT
(without any hesitation)

Main aatmaayein le jaane ka kaam karta hoon. Mujhe token ki zaroorat nahi.

SECURITY GUARD
Bina token koi andar nahi ja sakta, sir. Yeh niyam hai.

Yamdoot stares at him for a long moment — the eternal executive of the universe, defeated by a numbered slip of paper. He exhales, takes the token, and looks at it. It reads: "247. अनुमानित प्रतीक्षा समय: 3 घंटे।"

YAMDOOT
(to himself)
Teen ghante. Maine marte hue taaron ke kinare khada hokar bhi is se tez samay dekha hai.

He tucks the token into his pocket and walks straight in, ignoring the line, his patience for human procedure already exhausted.

SCENE 8.
INT. DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC SERVICES - CORRIDORS - DAY

Yamdoot moves through crowded corridors. People are arguing, crying, pleading. The walls are stained with paan spit. Fans creak overhead.

He approaches a PEON sitting on a plastic stool, chewing tobacco.

YAMDOOT
Pension department. Kahan hai?

The Peon looks him up and down, unimpressed even by the expensive suit.

PEON
Teesra floor. Lift kharab hai. Seediyan baayein taraf.

Yamdoot stares at him, no human warmth in his eyes. He slowly pulls a crisp 500-rupee note from his pocket and drops it into the Peon's lap.

PEON

(sits straight)
Aaiye sir, main chhod ke aata hoon.
Lift chala deta hoon aapke liye.

SCENE 9.
INT. PENSION SECTION - DAY

Yamdoot enters the same stifling, dusty room where Bholaram once used to come. The mountains of files seem to have grown even taller.

He walks past the Junior Clerk's desk, straight toward the HEAD CLERK (50s), a heavyset man in a safari suit, completely absorbed in playing Solitaire on his old desktop computer.

YAMDOOT
Mujhe ek file chahiye. Bholaram.
Sevanivritt clerk, Sinchai Vibhag.

HEAD CLERK
(without moving eyes form the screen)
File process mein hai. Baahar wait karo.

Yamdoot leans over the desk. He lowers his glasses. For a moment, total darkness flashes in his eyes. The temperature in the room drops ten degrees. The Head Clerk shivers, finally looking up.

YAMDOOT
Main yaha rukhne nahi aaya hu. Main le jaane aaya hoon. Dhoondo. Abhi.

The Head Clerk gulps nervously, frightened by a power he cannot comprehend. Shakily, he points toward the back of the room.

HEAD CLERK
Archives... peeche. Section C, Row 12.
Par wahan bahut dhool hai sir...

Yamdoot turns and walks toward the maze of papers.

SCENE 10.

INT. PENSION SECTION - ARCHIVES - LATER

Yamdoot walks through the cramped, suffocating aisles of paper. The sheer volume of decaying files is dreadful to look at.

He searches through endless stacks. Forms, rejections, duplicate requests — all yellowed with age.

Finally, he finds it. Buried beneath a pile of discarded notices. A thick, dusty manila folder. Its cover bears a faded label: "BHOLARAM — PENSION FILE — (Status: Under Review)."

Yamdoot pulls it out, brushing the dust off his suit. He opens it.

Just papers. Forms. Signatures. Missing stamps.

YAMDOOT
(Khud se)
Kuch nahi. Yeh hai kahan?

As he's about to close the folder, a faint, hazy whisper rises from the papers themselves.

VOICE (O.S.)
Sahab...

Yamdoot stops. He looks down the aisle. Empty.

VOICE (O.S.)
Sahab... mera sign baaki hai...

Yamdoot looks down at the file in his hands.

Slowly, strangely, the ink stains and marks on the yellowed paper begin to shift. A faint, ghostly image of Bholaram's tired face starts to emerge on the page.

Bholaram's soul is, quite literally, trapped between the pages of his own pension file.

YAMDOOT
(Stunned)
Bholaram?

BHOLARAM'S SOUL
(Voice echoing, Softly)

Ji sahab. Bholaram. Aap pension wale babu hain? Form 16-B laaya hoon main...

YAMDOOT
Bholaram, main clerk nahi hoon. Main Yamdoot hoon. Parlok Vibhag se aaya hoon. Tumhara sthool sharir samapt ho chuka hai. Prithvi par tumhara samay poora hua. Tumhe mere saath chalna hoga.

The face in the file fills with fear.

BHOLARAM'S SOUL
Nahi! Nahi sahab, main nahi jaa sakta!

YAMDOOT
Yeh vinati nahi hai. Yeh ek brahmandiya aadesh hai. Is kagazi jaal se khud ko azad karo.

BHOLARAM'S SOUL
(slowly crying)
Aap samajh nahi rahe. Meri pension baaki hai. Paanch saal ki pension. Ghar mein meri patni bhookhi hai. Beti ki shadi karni hai. Agar main chala gaya, toh yeh file yahin dab jayegi.

YAMDOOT
Tum mar chuke ho, Bholaram. Jahan tum ja rahe ho, wahan paise ka koi mol nahi.

BHOLARAM'S SOUL
Par unke liye toh hai na jo zinda hain? Jab tak is file pe 'Cleared' ka thappa nahi lagta, mera jeev yahin rahega. In panno ke beech.

Yamdoot stares at the file. For the first time in centuries, the executive of death is rendered utterly speechless. Bureaucracy has broken a man so completely that his consciousness has abandoned the universe to cling to red tape.

SCENE 11.

INT. PENSION SECTION - ARCHIVES - CONTINUOUS

As Yamdoot turns to leave, defeated, a second whisper rises from a nearby shelf — older, fainter still.

SECOND VOICE (O.S.)
Beta... mera bhi ek sign baaki hai...

Yamdoot turns, startled. He pulls another file from the shelf, even more decayed than the first. Cobwebs cling to its edges. The label reads: "SAVITRI DEVI — WIDOW PENSION — (Status: Under Review) — Filed 12 years ago."

On its cover, a faint, elderly face begins to glow — old, gentle, filled with quiet acceptance.

SAVITRI DEVI'S SOUL
(Weakly)
Baarah saal ho gaye beta. Mera pati sena mein the. Unki pension bhi aisi hi atki thi. Main bhi yahin reh gayi... file ke andar.

Yamdoot looks from one file to the other, then out at the endless aisles stretching around him — hundreds of thousands of identical folders receding into the darkness. A cold, mounting horror spreads across his face.

YAMDOOT
(Barely whispering)
Tum log kitne ho is andar?

No answer. Only the faint, dry rustle of paper, as though something alive were breathing in the dark.

ACT THREE

SCENE 12.
INT. DEPARTMENT OF AFTERLIFE - DAY

Yamdoot stands before Yamraj's vast desk, his posture rigid but unusually shaken. Yamraj and Chitragupt both stare at him in total silence.

YAMRAJ
Mujhe yeh samajhne do. Kya tum kehna chahte ho ki Prithvilok ke ek nagrik ki

aatma parlok mein aane se mana kar rahi hai... kyunki uski pension abhi tak jaari nahi hui?

YAMDOOT
Sirf ek nahi, Maharaj. Vahi par mujhe ek doosri file bhi mili. Ek vidhwa. Baarah saal se vichaardheen. Ho sakta hai wahan sainkdon aur ho. Woh imarat khud ek aisa shamshaan hai jiska humein kabhi pata hi nahi chala.

Chitragupt's tablet nearly slips from his hands.

CHITRAGUPT
(Furiously typing on the tablet)
Maharaj, main paralok-shastra ke niyamon ki jaanch kar raha hoon. Taknikee roop se -- agar kisi aatma ka lagaav kisi vastu se poorn ho jaaye, toh woh usi se bandh sakti hai. Unka jeevan is bureaucracy ke chakra mein itna dooba raha ki unki chetna ab us file se alag hi nahi ki ja sakti.

Yamraj removes his glasses and rubs his temples. He is deeply irritated — and, for the first time, faintly rattled.

YAMRAJ
Is brahmaand mein mrityu se bhi zyada hathdharmi shakti. Theek hai. Agar aatma ko nikaalne ke liye file saaf karni padegi, toh file saaf karo.

Yamraj points a finger at Chitragupt.

YAMRAJ
(Cont'd)
Unhe sampark karo. Prithvi ke Pension Karyalaya ko. Mera pura prabhaav dikhao. Woh pension aaj hi jaari karwao taaki mere abhilekh update ho sakein.

SCENE 13.
INT. PENSION SECTION - CONTINUOUS

The Head Clerk is back at his desk, picking his teeth with a matchstick. The heavy black rotary phone on his desk rings loudly.

He lets it ring five times, then picks it up lazily.

HEAD CLERK
Pension anubhag. Lunch ke baad call karo.

CHITRAGUPT (V.O.)
(In a loud, authoritative voice)
Main Chitragupt bol raha hoon. Mukhya Lekha Adhikari, Parlok Vibhag. Adhyaksh Yamraj ki ore se sampark kar raha hoon.

The Head Clerk pauses, pulls the phone away from his ear to look at it, then puts it back. To this system, even gods are just another department.

HEAD CLERK
Haan toh? Yahan Parlok ka quota nahi hai. Kiska kaam hai?

CHITRAGUPT (V.O.)
Humare paas ek mrit vyakti hai. Bholaram. Sinchai Vibhag. Uski aatma sach mein aapki pending files mein phansi hui hai. Yeh brahmandiya santulan bigaad rahi hai. Hum maang karte hain ki aap uski pension turant saaf karein taaki woh aage badh sake.

A long, unbearable silence. The fan continues thwacking in the background.

The Head Clerk sighs, leaning back in his chair.

HEAD CLERK
(Without emotion)
Kya hua? File toh process mein hai.

SCENE 14.
INT. DEPARTMENT OF AFTERLIFE - CONTINUOUS

Chitragupt puts the phone on speaker, looking helplessly at Yamraj.

CHITRAGUPT
Kya tumne suna nahi? Woh vyakti mar chuka hai. Uski sachchi aatma is kagazi jaal mein phansi hui hai.

HEAD CLERK (V.O.)
(Through the speaker)
Aise nahi hota sir. System hai. Ek aur signature bacha hai. Gazetted officer ka. Unko bolna kal aake sign karein, tabhi file aage badhegi. Marre hai toh death certificate ki teen copy notary kara ke laani padegi.

Yamraj leans forward, his voice becoming a deep, terrifying rumble that shakes the boardroom's glass walls.

YAMRAJ
Sunn, tuchh lipik! Main Yamraj hoon. Mrityu ka adhipati. Main tujhe aadesh deta hoon us file ko chhod, warna main tujhe tere samay se pehle hi yahan ghaseet laaunga!

HEAD CLERK (V.O.)
Dhamki mat dijiye sir. Duty mein baadha daalne ki police complaint kar dunga.

Yamraj is stunned into silence. The astonishing audacity of this earthly clerk has left even the Lord of Death speechless.

CHITRAGUPT
(Helplessly)
Kitna samay lagega? Bas itna bata do isse process karne mein kitna waqt lagega!

HEAD CLERK (V.O.)
Sir, aapko soochit kar diya jaayega.

The line cuts off with a sharp CLICK.

A moment of silence. Then Chitragupt, hopeful, redials — this time reaching an automated hold line. Thin, cheerful hold music plays from the speaker: a tinny, looping devotional flute tune.

AUTOMATED VOICE (V.O.)
(In a thin, mechanical voice)
Aapki call hamare liye mahatvapurn hai. Kripya line par bane rahein. Aapka anumanit wait time hai... teen sau saathath minute.

Yamraj stares at the phone. Three hundred and sixty-eight minutes. The Lord of Death, who in the entire history of the universe has never waited for anything, is now on hold.

YAMRAJ
(Slowly, to himself)
Mrityu bhi ek nagrik ko is *Prashasnik* se mukt nahi karwa sakti.

He sets the receiver down gently, as though handling a great defeat.

SCENE 15.
INT. PENSION SECTION - ARCHIVES - LATE EVENING

A vast, slow, sweeping shot of the huge, dim room filled with millions of decaying files. Its scale is immense — an endless graveyard of paper and broken promises. On screen appears the text: "लालफीताशाही कभी नहीं मरती।"

The camera slowly zooms in, passing through aisles and shelves, until it settles on the stack holding Bholaram's file, beside Savitri Devi's.

The faint, sorrowful image of Bholaram's tired face still lingers on the yellowed paper, his stack next to hers.

A heavy red stamp is marked across his face. It reads: UNDER REVIEW.

As the camera pulls back further, faint, ghostly faces begin to glow across hundreds of other folders in the archive — a whole silent congregation of forgotten people, waiting in the dark for a signature that will never come.

FADE TO BLACK.

TITLE CARD: BHOLARAM KA JEEV (BHOLARAM'S SOUL)